add, especially for women and girls, and therefore of beauty. Model-actress Poulomi Das recounted how she was on the verge of bagging a lead role in a television show only to learn that the channel rejected her on grounds of skin colour.

Ironically, five years ago, Das was the face of Glow & Lovely, the new name for India's most famous skin-whitening cream brand, after worldwide protests, including the #BlackLivesMatter movement, saw Hindustan Unilever replace the word 'fair' with 'glow' in 2020. That change proved to be, well, cosmetic. The skin lightening business is a booming one in India, worth $1.3-1.5 billion (Rs 11,100-12,800 crore) currently, with a projected compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of around 6.5-7.2 per cent over the next decade, according to a report on the subject by the Pune-based market research firm Future Market Insights. Fairness continues to be the ideal of beauty, with few dark-skinned role models in mainstream media or Hindi films, while social media is replete with visual representations of fairness as a marker of success and happiness.

Meanwhile, despite growing awareness, matrimonial advertisements continue to exhibit a preference for "light-skinned" brides. A 2018 survey of such ads showed that over 60 per cent of the men wanted fair-skinned women. "Women's bodies are their currency in the marriage market. For a dark-skinned man who is doing well financially, marrying a light-skinned normatively beautiful woman can be a trophy to further signal his status and power," says Radhika Parameswaran, professor at The Media School, Indiana University, US, who has done extensive research on colourism in India. "And as is the case in many different countries where physical appearance becomes an insidious factor in workplace success and mobility, it is not surprising that Indians, and especially women, worry that all things



THE SCIENCE OF SKIN

Or how homo sapiens got their skin colour

↘ Studies indicate that we were all born black two million years ago. Out of the jungle, it's because the body produced melanin to protect skin against sunlight that the species survived

↘ Among migrants to the northern latitudes, positive selection favoured those with reduced melanin levels: to get Vitamin D in scarce sunlight

↘ Modern humans derive their colour from the melanocortin 1 receptor or MC1R gene

↘ The colour of our skin is derived from our biological parents. Our melanocytes produce two types of melanin—eumelanin, a pigment that is responsible for darker skin tones and hair colours, and pheomelanin, which gives lighter skin tones and red hair